

FOUNDATIONS & BIG-O ANALYSIS

FAANG Interview Orientation — Mentor Guide

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ORIENTATION · BIG-O RULES · COMPLEXITY DEDUCTION

THE REAL-WORLD STORY

Imagine transferring a 100 GB file across town. Wi-Fi scales linearly with file size (100 GB = 200 min) → **O(N)**. Driving a USB drive takes fixed time regardless of size (100 GB = 30 min) → **O(1)**.

THE BIG-O AHA MOMENT

Big-O notation measures how runtime or memory scales as input size N grows to infinity, ignoring hardware speed differences!

WHY NOT MEASURE SECONDS?

- A fast CPU runs bad code quickly on tiny inputs.
- OS background processes alter millisecond execution timings.
- Big-O gives a universal mathematical upper bound guaranteed on all FAANG evaluation servers!

BIG-O GROWTH HIERARCHY

Big-O	Name	Max N for 1 Sec (10 ⁸ ops)
O(1)	Constant	Unlimited
O(log N)	Logarithmic	10 ¹⁸ (Binary Search)
O(N)	Linear	10 ⁸ (Single Pass)
O(N log N)	Linearithmic	10 ⁶ (Sorting)
O(N ²)	Quadratic	10 ⁴ (Nested Loops)
O(2 ^N) / O(N!)	Exponential	20 / 11 (Recursion)

THE 3 BIG-O REDUCTION RULES

Rule 1 — Drop Constants: $O(2N + 5) \rightarrow O(N)$. We care about growth rate, not constant multipliers.

Rule 2 — Drop Non-Dominant Terms: $O(N^2 + 100N + 500) \rightarrow O(N^2)$. N^2 dominates N as N grows.

Rule 3 — Multi-Variable Rules: Array A size N, Array B size M → **O(N + M)** for sequential loops, **O(N · M)** for nested loops!

5-STEP FAANG PROBLEM SOLVING FRAMEWORK

1. **Clarify Constraints:** Ask N limits ($N \leq 10^5 \Rightarrow O(N \log N)$ target).
2. **State Brute Force:** Mention naive solution & complexity first.
3. **Identify Bottleneck:** Spot repeated work → HashMap/Binary Search.
4. **Optimize & Code:** Write clean, modular Java standard code.
5. **Dry Run Test Cases:** Step line-by-line with small/edge inputs!

DEDUCING TARGET COMPLEXITY DIRECTLY FROM INPUT CONSTRAINTS (N)

Input Size (N)	Target Time Complexity	Typical Algorithm Patterns
$N \leq 10..12$	$O(N!)$ or $O(2^N \cdot N)$	Permutations, N-Queens, Backtracking Bitmask
$N \leq 20..25$	$O(2^N)$	Subsets, Combination Sum, Meet-in-the-Middle
$N \leq 500$	$O(N^3)$	Floyd-Warshall, Matrix Chain Multiplication DP
$N \leq 2,000$	$O(N^2)$	Nested Loops, 2D Grid DP, All-Pairs Check
$N \leq 10^5..10^6$	$O(N \log N)$ or $O(N)$	Sorting, Binary Search, Two Pointers, HashMap, Sliding Window
$N \leq 10^9..10^{18}$	$O(\log N)$ or $O(1)$	Binary Search on Answer, Bit Manipulation, Math Formulas

JAVA TOOLKIT & FAANG DRY RUN PROTOCOL

Auxiliary Memory, Pitfalls & Verification Protocol

AUXILIARY SPACE VS CALL STACK

- **Input Space:** Memory used to store input data (e.g. array of size N).
- **Auxiliary Space:** Extra memory created by your code (DS + call stack).
- **Recursion Call Stack:** `factorial(3)` calls `factorial(2)` → Max stack depth 3 => **O(N) Auxiliary Space!**

ESSENTIAL JAVA DATA STRUCTURE COMPLEXITIES

Data Structure	Operation	Time Complexity
`ArrayList`	`add()`, `get(i)`, `remove(last)`	O(1) amortized
`HashMap`	`put()`, `get()`, `containsKey()`	O(1) average, O(N) worst
`HashSet`	`add()`, `contains()`, `remove()`	O(1) average
`ArrayDeque`	`push()`, `pop()`, `offer()`, `poll()`	O(1) strictly faster than Stack
`PriorityQueue`	`offer()`, `poll()`, `peek()`	O(log N) offer/poll, O(1) peek

JAVA INTERVIEW POWER SNIPPETS

```
// 1. Frequency Map Shortcut:
map.put(key, map.getOrDefault(key, 0) + 1);

// 2. Sort Array in Reverse Order:
Arrays.sort(arr, (a, b) -> Integer.compare(b, a));

// 3. Min Heap & Max Heap Declarations:
PriorityQueue<Integer> minHeap = new PriorityQueue<>();
PriorityQueue<Integer> maxHeap = new PriorityQueue<>((a, b) -> b - a);

// 4. String Array to Char Manipulation:
char[] chars = str.toCharArray();
String sortedStr = new String(chars);
```

COMMON JAVA INTERVIEW BUGS & FIXES

- 1. Binary Search Mid Overflow:**
`int mid = (left + right) / 2;` → ❌ Overflows if `left + right > 2^31 - 1`!
`int mid = left + (right - left) / 2;` → ✅ Safe formula!
- 2. String Immutability Loop Overhead:**
`String s += "a";` in loop → ❌ Recreates string in O(N^2) total time!
`StringBuilder sb = new StringBuilder(); sb.append('a');` → ✅ O(1) amortized!

THE 4-STEP FAANG DRY RUN METHOD

1. **Pick a Small Concrete Input:** Choose a simple test case e.g. `nums = [2, 7, 11]`, `target = 9`.
2. **Create a Variable State Table:** Write columns for line numbers, loop counters, pointers, and key data structures.
3. **Step Line-by-Line:** Execute code manually step-by-step. Do NOT skip iterations!
4. **Test Edge Cases:** Test empty inputs, 1-element arrays, duplicates, and out-of-bounds bounds.

SAMPLE VARIABLE STATE TRACE TABLE

Line	i	nums[i]	complement	map state	Action
1	0	2	7	{}	`map.put(2, 0)`
2	1	7	2	{2: 0}	Match Found! Return `[0, 1]`

ORIENTATION MASTERY CHECKLIST

- ☐ Explain Big-O using real-world analogies (Wi-Fi vs Car)
- ☐ Deduce target complexity directly from input size N
- ☐ State 3 Big-O reduction rules without hesitation
- ☐ Use safe mid formula `left + (right - left) / 2`
- ☐ Differentiate Input Space vs Auxiliary Call Stack Space
- ☐ Perform 4-step line-by-line variable trace dry runs

GOLDEN RULES — NEVER FORGET

Rule 1 — State Brute Force First

Always state the obvious brute force solution and its time/space complexity before jumping into optimization! It shows structured thinking.

Rule 2 — Dry Run Saves You from Rejection

90% of interview bugs (off-by-one errors, null pointers, unhandled edge cases) are caught during your dry run before running tests!